



Class apart:
Eight-time
champion
Germany will be
led by Lea
Schuller in the
front.

in the 2024 UEFA Nations League final. The Spaniards will aim to become only the second women's team in history to win consecutive World Cup and EURO tournaments after Germany, which won five in a row between 2001 and 2009 (2003 and 2007 World Cups, 2001, 2005 and 2009 Euros).

The EUROs have not been a happy hunting ground for the Spaniards, however, as they could not make it past the quarterfinals in each of the last three editions and have never reached a final. While they will miss all-time top scorer Jenni Hermoso (57 goals from 123 caps) after she failed to make the cut, Spain would still be the prime favourite, with Opta saying it has a 24.8 per cent chance of lifting the title.

Sarina Wiegman's England will be keen to become only the second team in the competition's history to successfully defend its title, after beating Germany 2-1 in the 2022 final at the Wembley Stadium. However, the Lionesses' build-up to the tournament has been tumultuous.

England's No.1 keeper, Mary Earps, retired from international duty just six weeks before the tournament. Millie Bright chose not to play in the competition, prioritising her mental and physical well-being, and 22-year-old defender Ella Morris suffered an ACL injury, ruling her out.

However, it is not all doom and gloom for England. It will still have plenty of experience, with players such as Lauren James, Alessia Russo, Lauren Hemp and Beth Mead (**facing page, below**; Golden Boot winner in the last edition with six goals). Add to that Wiegman's match-winning formula, and the Lionesses might go on to defend their title. England has won each of its 14 group-stage games at major tournaments (World Cup/EUROs), the longest-ever such run by a European nation.

Who will be the dark horse?

Not much pomp and attention surrounds Andrea Sorcin's Italy side, but it can cause a few upsets, as it has shown the capability to beat the heavyweights on its day.

Five players to watch out for



Marie-Antoinette Katoto (France)

Celin Bizet Ildhusoy (Norway)

Stina Blackstenius (Sweden)

Mariona Caldentey (Spain)

Ewa Pajor (Poland)

Participating teams



Group A

Switzerland, Norway, Iceland, Finland

Group B

Spain, Portugal, Belgium, Italy

Group C

Germany, Poland, Denmark, Sweden

Group D

France, England, Wales, Netherlands

Even though it has not been able to gain any momentum ahead of the tournament, it could spoil the plans of other teams in its group. However, consistency remains the biggest issue for Sorcin's group. Placed in a challenging Group B alongside world champion Spain, Belgium (that beat defending champion England 3-2), and Portugal (that drew 1-1 with the Lionesses), the first aim would be to make it out of the Group of Death and reach the quarterfinals.

While international tournaments have often had fairytale stories, realistic predictions suggest a quarterfinal run would be considered a good tournament for the Italians. Anything beyond that will be a bonus.

How is the record-time champion placed?

Eight-time winner Germany (that won this tournament six consecutive times between 1995-2013) might not rank ahead of teams like Spain and England in terms of being favourites to win the title this time. However, it's a strong contender to reach the latter stages of the tournament. In the last edition, the Germans came close to defending their title.

While boasting a decent balance in midfield and defence, it is the attacking department that looks exciting for the record-time champion. Finding the net should not be a problem for Germany, with Bayern Munich's Lea Schuller (52 goals in 75 games) leading the charge, alongside another exciting talent in Selina Cerci.

The Germans are not short of momentum. It has remained unbeaten this year (W5, D1) and have also reached the Nations League final in consecutive seasons. While a ninth crown looks slightly out of reach, expect to see them in the semifinals.